

OPEN MARKET HANDSETS FOR CDMA SERVICES

The open market handset (OMH) initiative promises to enhance the CDMA ecosystem. It gives consumers the flexibility in CDMA device as well as operator selection, which was not easy earlier

■ EFY BUREAU

Now you have a greater choice and flexibility to stay tuned to the CDMA ecosystem. Open Market Handset (OMH), an initiative led by CDMA development group (CDG) to enhance the CDMA customer base, offers CDMA customers the flexibility to switch handsets or service providers with ease. Reliance Communications, Sistema Shyam (MTS), Tata Teleservices and Virgin Mobile India are the operators supporting this initiative in India. Samsung and Micromax have already launched their OMH handsets.

"When CDMA phones were first launched in India, people were sceptical about getting tied to the operator with a SIM-card-less phone, especially with the GSM phones having no such constraint," shares Sandeep Sibal, country manager and vice president of technology, Qualcomm India & South Asia. "Open market handsets are operator-neutral not only for voice but also for data. This has created greater selection of devices for consumers," he adds.

"CDMA as a technology is well-positioned to have great future. There is a business case to put more smartphones and higher-end CDMA phones in India for CDMA customers," says Atul Joshi, chief sales officer, MTS.

What is OMH?

OMH is part of the Global Handset Requirements for CDMA (GHRC)

initiative. GHRC brings the diverse group of operators and vendors for handsets, applications and chipsets together to facilitate delivery of feature-rich and affordable 3G devices across the globe. There are about 40+ companies (operators, OEMs and chipset providers) working jointly to develop standards and specifications based on the carrier requirement and device functionality.

The first worldwide trial of OMH was completed in India in August 2008. Also, the first commercial open market handset, Mpower 699,

was launched by Samsung in India in August 2009. "India being the second largest market for mobile phones in the world with over 110 million subscribers, was a natural choice to begin the programme," explains Sibal. "Today, we have about six open market handsets in the market. We plan to launch 25+ open market handsets this year, ranging from entry-level phones to high-end multimedia phones," Sibal adds.

Joshi expects the OMH market to see double-digit growth as it offers convergence of voice and data with ease of operation.

Technological change

In the OMH ecosystem, the complete configuration settings to support operator and subscriber identification are shifted from the handset to the removable user interface module (R-UMI) card, commonly known as OHM SIM card.

"Earlier, only the voice and SMS were provisioned on the SIM card. By moving the network settings for data onto the SIM card, the handset is made operator-neutral,"



Samsung Mpower 699